



A GUIDE FOR SRI LANKAN PARENTS

Protecting Children From **HARMFUL CONTENT**

How to filter, guide, and talk with your child
about what they see online



WWW.IFDCHILD.ORG

Parental control tools, real settings, and reporting contacts

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Why This Guide

Most parents' first instinct, on hearing about a child stumbling onto something disturbing online, is to reach for an app that promises to block it. That instinct is reasonable — filtering tools genuinely help — but it is worth being honest about their limits from the outset, rather than discovering them later. Every filter, however good, is built on a list of what its makers already know about; the internet changes faster than any list can keep up with, and a curious, tech-savvy child will often find a way around a restriction within days of it being set. That is not a reason to skip the tools in this guide — it is a reason to pair them with something no software can replace: a child who already knows what to do when a filter fails, because you talked about it before it happened.

1. What Counts as Inappropriate Content

“Inappropriate content” is a wide net, and it helps to know roughly what sits inside it, since different types call for different responses. Broadly, it covers material that is not suited to a child's age and could affect how they feel, think, or behave — including sexually explicit images or video, graphic violence, hate speech, content that promotes self-harm or extreme dieting, and material that recruits or radicalises, sometimes dressed up as an ordinary-looking video or game.

Two distinctions are worth holding onto. First, accidental versus sought-out exposure: a child who stumbles onto something through a mistyped web address is in a different situation from one actively searching for it, and the right response differs — the first calls for reassurance and better filtering, the second for a calmer, more curious conversation about why they went looking. Second, a one-off glimpse versus repeated exposure: a single accidental encounter, while unpleasant, is usually not the same order of concern as content a child keeps returning to, which is more often a sign that something else — curiosity, peer pressure, or an unmet need — needs addressing directly.

2. How Children Actually Encounter It

The stereotype of a child “searching for the wrong thing” covers only a small share of real cases. Most exposure happens sideways, through ordinary use of ordinary apps:



An innocent search leads somewhere else

e.g. a misspelled site, or an image search gone wrong



Shared by a friend

forwarded in a group chat as a joke or a dare



Pop-ups & autoplay

ads or 'next video' suggestions on video sites



Contact from a stranger

in games, forums, or social media DMs

The four most common routes children encounter harmful content

EXAMPLE

A ten-year-old searches an innocent term for a school project. The image results include several that have nothing to do with the search and everything to do with how loosely tagged the internet actually is — no malicious intent from the child at all, just a search engine returning what it returned.

This matters for how you think about prevention: a filter that only blocks a list of “bad” sites will miss most of these routes, because the content usually arrives through a completely ordinary site — a video platform, a group chat, a game — that is not itself blockable. This is exactly why Section 4 talks about layering several types of protection rather than relying on any single one.

3. Warning Signs Your Child May Have Seen Something

Most children who see something disturbing online do not immediately tell a parent — often because they are confused about what they saw, worried they will be blamed for finding it, or afraid their device will be taken away. As with other online risks, changes in behaviour are usually a more reliable signal than waiting to be told directly.

- Sudden reluctance to use a device they previously enjoyed, or the opposite — secretive, single-minded return to it
- Quickly closing a tab, app, or switching screens when you walk past
- Nightmares, difficulty sleeping, or new fears that don't have an obvious source
- Using words, phrases, or ideas well beyond what you'd expect for their age
- Increased anxiety, aggression, or withdrawal without a clear cause
- Direct questions that hint at something specific: “Why would someone do that to another person?” asked out of nowhere

Remember

- A child who has seen something disturbing is not in trouble. How you respond in the first conversation shapes whether they come to you next time, or quietly deal with it alone.

Supportive Steps for Navigating Digital Distress

A four-step guide for parents when a child encounters upsetting content online



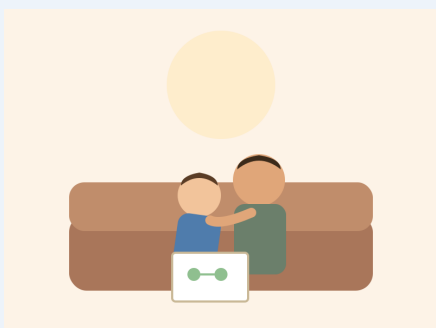
1. Recognize the Signs

Watch for behavior, not just words: mood shifts, withdrawal from family time, or secretive, intense focus on a device can signal something is wrong.



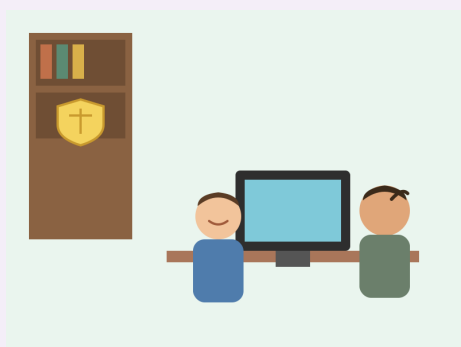
2. Create a Safe Space to Talk

Approach gently and sit beside them. Set the device aside as a shared topic, not a barrier. Listen first — you're there to support, not to punish.



3. Offer Reassurance & Perspective

Remind them: they are not alone, and it's not their fault. Validate their feelings, and help reframe the experience — the internet can be unpredictable.

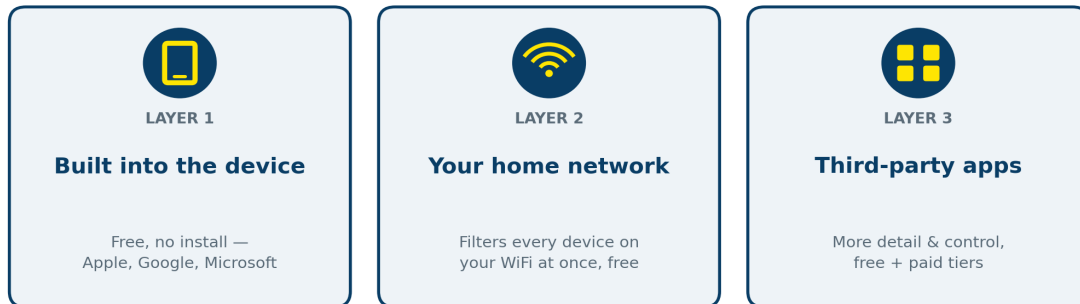


4. Prevent & Move Forward

Once the crisis has passed, build resilience together: review privacy settings, discuss reporting tools, and restore their sense of control.

4. Three Layers of Protection

No single tool covers everything, and chasing a single “perfect” app tends to waste time better spent combining a few simple, free layers. Most families are well served by stacking these three, from broadest to most specific:



Three layers, used together — not any one alone

The sections that follow walk through each layer, with accurate, current details and the real official link for every tool named — not logos, which go stale and can be reproduced by anyone, but the link itself, which takes you straight to the source.

5. Layer 1 — Built Into the Device (Free)

Before installing anything new, it's worth knowing that the device your child already has almost certainly includes a capable, free parental control system — built by the company that made the operating system, and usually the best-integrated option available.

Google Family Link

FREE

Android, Chromebook (limited iOS) · No cost

Lets you approve or block app downloads, filter content on Search, Chrome and YouTube, set screen time limits, and manage your child's Google Account. Works best when your child's device runs Android; iOS support is more limited.

Official site: families.google/familylink

Apple Screen Time

FREE

iPhone, iPad, Mac · No cost, built into Settings

Set up through Family Sharing, it offers Content & Privacy Restrictions to block explicit content and age-inappropriate apps, Communication Safety to flag sensitive photos/videos in Messages before they're sent or viewed, and Downtime scheduling.

Official site: support.apple.com/en-us/105121

Microsoft Family Safety

FREE

Windows, Xbox, Android, iOS app · No cost

Blocks inappropriate websites and apps, turns on safe search across Bing and other engines, sets screen time limits across Windows and Xbox, and lets a child request permission to visit a blocked site, which an adult can approve remotely.

Official site: family.microsoft.com

6. Layer 2 — Your Home Network (Free)

A network-level filter works differently from an app: instead of being installed on one device, it's set up once on your home router (or, alternatively, on individual devices), and then filters every device that connects to that network — including guest phones, smart TVs, and game consoles that don't support parental control apps at all.

OpenDNS FamilyShield

FREE

Router-wide, or per-device · No cost, no account needed

A free service from Cisco that blocks pornography and known malicious sites at the network level for every connected device, simply by changing your router's DNS settings. It has no screen-time or app-blocking features — it only filters explicit content — but it is genuinely set-and-forget, and worth having as a baseline even alongside other tools.

Official site: familyshield.opendns.com

7. Layer 3 — Third-Party Apps (Free & Paid)

If your family wants more detail than the built-in tools provide — activity reports, call and message monitoring, or a single dashboard across every device regardless of brand — a dedicated third-party app is the next step. It's worth being precise about pricing here, since it changes often and some older guides (including some still circulating online) get it wrong.

Qustodio

FREE + PAID

Windows, Mac, Android, iOS, Kindle · Free tier (1 device) · paid plans from ~US\$4–10/mo

The free plan covers a single device with core filtering and time limits. Paid Basic and Complete plans add more devices, call/SMS monitoring, YouTube monitoring, and panic-button location alerts. Widely regarded as one of the more complete options for families with mixed device types (some Android, some iOS).

Official site: qustodio.com

Kaspersky Safe Kids

FREE + PAID

Windows, Mac, Android, iOS · Limited free plan · paid plans, often bundled with Kaspersky Premium

Offers strong content filtering (independently tested and rated highly for blocking inappropriate sites) plus location tracking and screen time limits. Its iOS features are notably weaker than Android. Note: Kaspersky products are currently restricted in the United States over a government security order, but remain available in most other countries.

Official site: kaspersky.com/safe-kids

Norton Family (“Parental Control”)

PAID ONLY

Windows, Android, iOS (not macOS) · No free tier — roughly US\$50/yr standalone, or bundled with Norton 360

Norton removed its free tier back in 2018, so this is a paid-only option today — either as a standalone subscription or included with Norton 360 Deluxe and higher plans. Strong web filtering and location tracking; weaker on iOS than Android, and doesn't run on Mac.

Official site: family.norton.com

A caution worth taking seriously

- None of these tools are foolproof. A determined teenager can often find a workaround within days, and no filter can read context the way a person can — which is exactly why Sections 9 and 13 matter as much as this one.

8. Choosing What's Right for Your Family

There's no single “best” tool — the right choice depends mostly on your child's age and which devices they actually use.

Younger children (under 10), mostly on a shared or supervised device

The built-in options in Section 5 are usually enough on their own — Google Family Link or Apple Screen Time, depending on the device. There's little reason to add a paid app at this stage; supervision and shared spaces do most of the work.

Ages 10–13, with a first personal phone

Pair the device's built-in tool with OpenDNS FamilyShield on your home router for a free, two-layer baseline. This is also the age to start explaining that the filter exists and why, rather than presenting it as a silent restriction — a child who understands the reasoning is far less motivated to work around it.

Teenagers, or families wanting more detail

Consider a paid third-party app like Qustodio if activity reports and cross-platform coverage matter to you — but go in aware that most teenagers this age can identify when they're being closely monitored, and that trust, not surveillance, is what tends to keep the conversation open when something does go wrong.

9. Talking With Your Child About What They See

A filter can block a website. It cannot explain why what a child saw was upsetting, or help them make sense of it. That part is always the parent's job, and it goes better when the conversation happens before an incident, not only after one.

Before anything happens

Introduce the idea simply and without drama: sometimes the internet shows people things they didn't ask for and wouldn't have chosen, and if that ever happens, the right move is to close it and tell you — not to hide it out of worry they'll be blamed.

Parent: *Sometimes when you're online, you might see something that makes you feel weird or uncomfortable, even if you weren't looking for it. If that ever happens, you're not in trouble — just close it and come tell me, okay?*

Child: *What kind of thing?*

Parent: *Could be a scary video, or pictures that aren't meant for kids. You don't need to know exactly what it is to know the rule: close it, tell me, and we'll figure it out together.*

After it's already happened

If your child tells you — or you discover — that they've seen something disturbing, the instinct to interrogate (“what exactly did you see,” “how did you get there”) is understandable but usually counterproductive in the first few minutes. Start with how they're feeling, not with the facts.

Child: *I saw something on my friend's phone... I don't really want to talk about it.*

Parent: *That's okay, you don't have to describe it if you don't want to. I just want to know — are you okay right now?*

Child: *I don't know. It was scary.*

Parent: *That makes sense, and I'm glad you told me. We don't need to sort everything out tonight. I'm here if you want to talk about it more, now or later.*

10. What To Do If Your Child Has Already Seen Something Disturbing

- **1. Stay calm and lead with reassurance — your reaction sets the tone for whether they tell you next time.**
- **2. Let them describe as much or as little as they're comfortable with — don't press for details they're not offering.**
- **3. If it's safe and simple to do, note where and how it happened, since this tells you which layer of protection (Section 4) needs adjusting.**

- **4. Check in over the following days, not just once — disturbing content can surface as bad dreams or anxiety a few days later.**
- **5. If the material appears to involve the exploitation or abuse of a child, or content that is illegal in Sri Lanka, report it (see Section 11) rather than only blocking it locally.**
- **6. If distress continues beyond a couple of weeks, or affects sleep, appetite, or school, a school counsellor or one of the helplines in Section 12 is a reasonable next step.**

11. Reporting Harmful or Illegal Content in Sri Lanka

Blocking or deleting harmful content protects your own child in the moment, but it doesn't stop it reaching someone else's. Where content is clearly illegal — child sexual abuse material, extremist recruitment, or content grooming or exploiting a child — reporting it to the right authority matters, and Sri Lanka has clear channels for this.

Sri Lanka CERT|CC

Handles reports of harmful, illegal, or malicious online content and can work with platforms to have it removed. Report via the online portal at cert.gov.lk, by emailing report@cert.gov.lk, or by calling 011 269 1692.

National Child Protection Authority (NCPA)

For any content involving the exploitation, abuse, or endangerment of a child, call the 24-hour Childline on 1929, free from any network, in Sinhala, Tamil, or English.

Police CCID

Where the content is clearly criminal — child sexual abuse material, grooming, or exploitation — this can and should also be reported to the Computer Crime Investigation Division on 011 238 1045 or dir.ccid@police.gov.lk.

On top of reporting

- Also use each platform's own “Report” function on the specific video, post, or account — this is usually the fastest way to get individual content removed, even while an official report is pending.

12. Helplines & Contacts Directory

Organisation	Contact	What they help with
NCPA Childline (1929)	1929	Free, 24/7, confidential. For any child-abuse or child-safety concern, including cyberbullying. Available in Sinhala, Tamil and English.
Sri Lanka CERT CC	011 269 1692 / report@cert.gov.lk	Report cyberbullying, fake profiles, harassment, defamation or hacked accounts online at cert.gov.lk/report_incident .
Police CCID (Cyber Crime)	011 238 1045	For criminal complaints such as threats, blackmail, image-based abuse or serious harassment. Email dir.ccid@police.gov.lk .

Organisation	Contact	What they help with
Police Emergency	119 / 118	For any situation involving immediate danger to your child.
Hithawathi	Counselling 077 567 6555 · Legal 076 868 6555	Confidential online-safety helpline and counselling for issues in cyberspace.
1938 Women & Children's Bureau	1938	Ministry of Women & Child Affairs helpline.
National Institute of Mental Health	1926 / WhatsApp +94 75 555 1926	Mental-health support helpline.
Sumithrayo	011 268 2535 / 011 268 2570	Emotional support and suicide-prevention helpline.

13. No Tool Replaces the Conversation

It's worth ending where this guide began: every tool in Sections 5 to 7 is genuinely useful, and setting at least one of them up is a good use of twenty minutes. But filters work on lists, and the internet changes faster than any list can. What actually keeps a child safer over years, not just days, is a relationship where telling you what they saw feels safer than hiding it — which is built in ordinary, unremarkable conversations, well before anything goes wrong.

This manual is intended as general guidance for parents and caregivers in Sri Lanka. Tool names, pricing, and features change over time — always confirm current details on the official site before relying on them. It does not replace professional legal, medical or psychological advice. If your child is in immediate danger, contact the Police on 119/118 without delay.



NO FILTER CATCHES EVERYTHING

Tools help, but conversation is what actually keeps your child safe. Use both, and start early.

QUICK REFERENCE

1929

NCPA Childline

Free, 24/7, confidential — if your child has seen harmful content

011 269 1692

Sri Lanka CERT|CC

report@cert.gov.lk — to report illegal or harmful websites

011 238 1045

Police CCID

Cyber-crime unit — exploitation material, grooming, serious abuse

119 / 118

Police Emergency

Immediate danger to your child

WWW.IFDCHILD.ORG

Keeping children safe online